

Getting Started with Thesis Writing in RMarkdown and L^AT_EX

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A short guide for curious and motivated researchers

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❧ *COLOPHON* ❧

This document was typeset in R Markdown and the text was set in EB Garamond. The data and code used to produce this document are available at <https://github.com/christelinda-laureijs/sample-thesis>.

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Introduction

Writing a paper in R is a challenging but rewarding process that will save you lots of time, effort and stress. If you're tired of repeatedly copying and pasting plots and p -values into Word and struggling with formatting issues, this book is for you! It contains tips and code snippets as well as answers to common questions about writing with R. Feel free to jump around to different sections and try things out in R as you go through the guide!

This book is part of a GitHub repository: <https://github.com/christelinda-laureijs/sample-thesis>. Although you can read the PDF format, I would highly recommend looking at the RMarkdown file used to produce it (Getting-Started.Rmd). It will show you the code used to produce this document, with lots of commented code samples throughout!

For screenshots, code, and more pictures, please take a look at How-to-Write-a-Paper-in-R-PDF.pdf. These are slides from a seminar that I presented as part of the Open Science Skills in R workshop series in January 2025.

If you want to start experimenting with a simple blank thesis folder, open sample-paper.Rmd and try knitting it!

What are the advantages of writing in R?

Efficiency

The biggest advantage of writing in R is that it makes your workflow very efficient. A typical workflow requires you to move between software and do lots of manual work:

1. Import, clean and process data
2. Run statistical tests
3. Copy the data to software like GraphPad Prism.
4. Create a plot
5. Adjust the plot to make it look better than the program defaults
6. Save or copy the plot
7. Paste the plot into Word
8. Add a figure caption and number it correctly.
9. Write the results section and paste in p -values and statistical output from Step 2.
10. Add a table of contents
11. Oh no! You found a mistake or you have new data! Or, you want to change the formatting of your plot(s)
12. Go back to step 1 and repeat
13. Oh no! You need to delete or move a section of the paper!
14. Re-number everything
15. Update the table of contents
16. Shift images and paragraphs around if they've created awkward page breaks.
17. Repeat as needed

With R, you can do everything in one document and a lot of it can be automated.

1. Import, clean and process data
2. Run statistical tests
3. Write code for a theme that applies formatting to all plots in the document
4. Create a plot
5. Write the figure caption.
6. Write the results section and use inline code to refer to p -values and statistical output
7. Click on the “Knit” button in RStudio
8. Your text, figures with figure captions, and statistical results will all appear in a PDF document!
9. If you change anything, click “Knit” again and R will automatically regenerate your PDF with

updated figures, p -values and statistical output tables.

10. To change the colours, fonts, or formatting of all your plots, modify the ggplot theme and everything will change if you “Knit” again.
11. If you move anything around, R will automatically re-number the sections and figure captions.

Rather than typing the same things over and over again, you can even set up functions to automate tasks like running a statistical test or creating many similar plots.

Reproducibility

Your analyses and text are all in one place, so you will always know what you did to create a specific plot or how you got a certain p -value. Others will be able to follow your process by reading your code, and if you make your code and data available, they can replicate your analyses (and ideally end up with the same results!). If you’re passionate about open science, this is a great way to make the entire writing process transparent.

No more manual formatting!

R will save you from spending a lot of time on manual formatting. The ggplot theme that you set up will ensure that your plots look consistent. You do not need to manually number your figures or sub-headings, format your Table of Contents, or readjust paragraphs each time you insert or remove a picture. You can easily cross-reference figures, equations and chapters. To insert a list of figures, just type `\listoffigures` – see, it’s very doable!

Typesetting details like paragraph spacing, margins, and fonts are all specified in the document preamble. You just need to write and $\LaTeX$ will handle the rest. This creates consistently formatted documents and allows you to focus on writing!

When it eventually comes time to print your thesis, you can easily change parameters like the binding offset and page layout.

Handles large, complex documents well

R makes it easy for you to manage large documents like a thesis or book because it allows for easy cross-referencing of figures, footnotes, quotes, and citations. Inserting a new page or image into a lengthy document (typically a harrowing process in Word) is not difficult in R and you have a lot of control over the layout of your sections. It's easy to move things around, and R will automatically re-number your figures, table of contents, list of figures and footnotes.

If you have a very large document, you could even consider breaking it up into smaller .Rmd files (called “child documents”) and knitting them into one “parent document”.

Beautiful typography

When you knit your document into a PDF, R uses $\LaTeX$ behind-the-scenes. $\LaTeX$ is a typesetting engine that uses mathematical algorithms to arrange text into the most ideal way according to typesetting rules. $\LaTeX$ automatically handles a lot of typesetting details including:

- Kerning - aesthetically pleasing spacing between letters based on their shapes
- Ligatures - new characters for letter combinations like *fi* and *ff*, which often crash into each other in Word documents (see Figure 1 for a comparison).
- Text justification without creating large gaps between words.
- Consistent styles for section headers, citations, figure captions and numbering, etc.
- and more!

Professional-quality typesetting has a huge impact on the appearance of the document. $\LaTeX$ -produced documents look very distinctive and after a while, you'll be able to easily tell the differences between a document produced using $\LaTeX$ vs. Word. Your writing will look neat, elegant, and perfectly arranged with minimal effort!



Figure 1: Ligatures are specialized characters that replace letter combinations like *fi*. Left: Word does not automatically include ligatures, so these letters clash. In this Word example, notice the collision between the curve of the *f* and the dot in *i*. The word *office* also has slightly misaligned *f*'s. Disclaimer: I used a Garamond typeface that doesn't have ligatures, which is why the letters look different than the ones on the right. Right: $\text{\LaTeX}$ has full support for ligatures. These words showcase the *ffi* and *fi* ligatures.

Alice was beginning to
get very tired of
sitting by her sister
on the bank, and of having
nothing to do: once or twice
she had peeped into the book
her sister was reading, but it
had no pictures or
conversations in it, “and
what is the use of a book,”
thought Alice “without
pictures or conversations?”

LICE was beginning
to get very tired of
sitting by her sister
on the bank, and of having
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“without pictures or conversa-
tions?”

Figure 2: This figure highlights some key differences between typesetting in Word (left) and $\text{\LaTeX}$ (right). Notice how Word creates a misaligned drop-cap and awkward justification, with several gaps (highlighted in red). $\text{\LaTeX}$ produces neatly aligned text, and it even uses small caps to emphasize the first word.

If you need to use equations, $\LaTeX$ is one of the best ways to create clean, well-aligned equations. Look in the $\LaTeX$ documentation to learn how to align by equal signs, make more complicated equations, or draw schematics!

$$\int_a^b x^2 dx \tag{1}$$

$$x = \frac{-b \pm \sqrt{b^2 - 4ac}}{2a} \tag{2}$$

Free

R, Rmarkdown, $\LaTeX$ and the packages you'll use are all free and open-source.

Uses plain text files

Your documents are plain text files, which means that they don't take up much space on your computer, and you can open them up years later in any plain text editor (even Notepad!). It also means that your files will always be available, and you won't get locked into a specific version of proprietary software.

Since RMarkdown is a plain-text document, your computer will be able to handle large documents much more easily than Word. It will not get buggy or crash when you have a huge document with lots of high-resolution pictures.

Version Control

Plaintext files like RMarkdown files are easy to track using version control software. I would highly recommend trying out R, Git and GitHub (which is also free). Each time you make a change to the document on your computer, Git will also save the changes to the online version of your file, hosted on GitHub. It means that you'll always have a backup copy, and if something wrong happens, you can revert back to an older version and see what changes you made.

P.S. For an introduction on incorporating version control with your paper, see chapter 2 of Open Science Skills in R!

What are the disadvantages of writing in R?

Learning curve

If you're not familiar with R, RMarkdown, and $\text{\LaTeX}$, it will take much longer to set up your paper than in Word. It will also take a while to format your preamble to make your document look exactly the way you want it. You'll likely spend a lot of time Googling things and reading through answers on StackOverflow and GitHub.

Troubleshooting

Things will break down, and you'll spend way more time than you had anticipated dealing with error messages. During these times, it does seem much easier to just open a Word document and start typing. To minimize errors, I would suggest these things:

- Put a “setup chunk” at the start of your RMD file with things like the colour themes, libraries you need, and ggplot themes. This is an efficient way to ensure that you have everything needed for later code chunks. See the setup chunk in the .Rmd file used to produce this document!
- Run each code chunk from top to bottom to catch any errors. Ensure that everything runs before knitting.
- Knit your document frequently as you go to help spot errors.
- R will knit documents using a blank R session, so everything that needs to be in the document must be defined in your script.
- Turn off the “Save workspace image” option in your R Global Options to prevent old loaded packages and hidden variables from ‘hovering’ in the background and creating strange errors.
- Frequently use `Run -> Restart R` and `clear output` to prevent objects from cluttering your workspace and causing dependencies. For example, if you define a variable in the console, but not your document you won't realize the problem until you have a fresh R session.
- Use `knitr::knit_exit()` to stop knitting early. It can be a useful way to identify the specific line of code that is causing knitting issues. This is also helpful if you have draft content below this chunk that you aren't ready to show in the final PDF.
- Make sure that your PDF is closed when you knit. If you're knitting the file and the PDF is still

open somewhere on your computer (e.g, in a browser, in Adobe PDF, etc.), it will break the knitting process and you will get errors.

- Be sure to use R Projects and a tidy project framework to make it easy for R and you to find things. See chapter 1 of the Open Science Skills in R website!
- If you're getting error messages about images not being found, don't forget to check your knit settings (dropdown arrow by the *Knit* icon). Click on the Project Directory setting. You may need to switch the Knit Directory from *Document Directory* to *Project Directory* or the other way around. If one directory isn't working, try the other!

Separate content and layout

You don't get to see what your document looks like until you knit it. This can be disconcerting for some people but great for others because you aren't distracted by formatting. Although you should knit your document often, don't fuss around with formatting until your paper is almost done. Things like paragraph spacing will change, and it is better to wait until the end.

At the beginning, you may worry about floats (things like pictures, plots, and tables). $\LaTeX$ will 'float' these over the text and then plop them down in a way that minimizes the number of paragraph breaks and blank spots. This means that your floats will often be further from where you want them. It is very, very difficult to 'force' floats to go into a specific spot, and the place that $\LaTeX$ chooses is often the best layout-wise. Always use references like Figure 1, rather than "the figure below".

Collaboration issues

Unlike Word, you can't use track changes, comments, or shared files. The best way to simulate this is to set up a GitHub repository and add your supervisor as a collaborator. They could then use pull requests to suggest changes. This may cause issues if you have a supervisor who doesn't know how to use GitHub. You also may not be able to make this work if your supervisor doesn't want to or know how to comment a PDF.

How-Tos

Inserting citations

Citation managers like Zotero (free; highly recommended) make it easy to link your citations in R. You will need the BetterBibTeX plugin, and enable citation keys. You can then export your Zotero collection as a .bib file (ensure that *keepUpdated* is checked to make the .bib file auto-update). For more instructions with screenshots, please see slides 68 and onwards in How-to-Write-a-Paper-in-R-PDF.pdf.

Now, you can type something like `[@delamonte2005]`, and the citation will be rendered as an in-text citation: (De La Monte & Wands, 2005).

This document uses APA formatting because of the ‘apa.csl’ file in the `Templates/` folder. If you want a different format, you can download the appropriate CSL file online and replace `apa.csl` with your new csl file name in the YAML header.

Inserting plots

You can plot figures in R. This is one of the best parts - R will generate the plots each time the document knits so you don’t have to repeatedly copy and paste pictures into your paper!

Inserting images

You can insert images that were generated elsewhere (.PNG, .JPG, etc.) through knitr. This gives you the option to add figure captions, adjust the relative size of the image, and much more. The chunk option

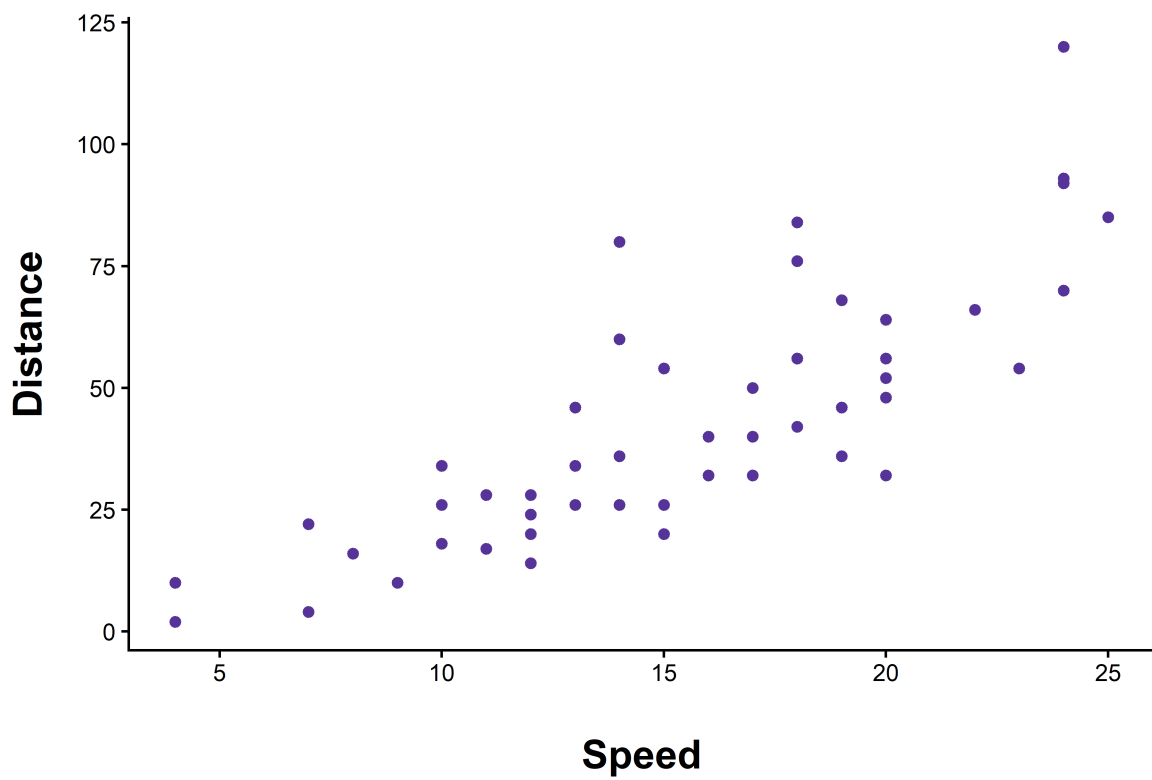


Figure 3: Braking distance is positively correlated with driving speed.

`fig.cap` is for the figure caption that will appear within the paper. This caption can be quite long.

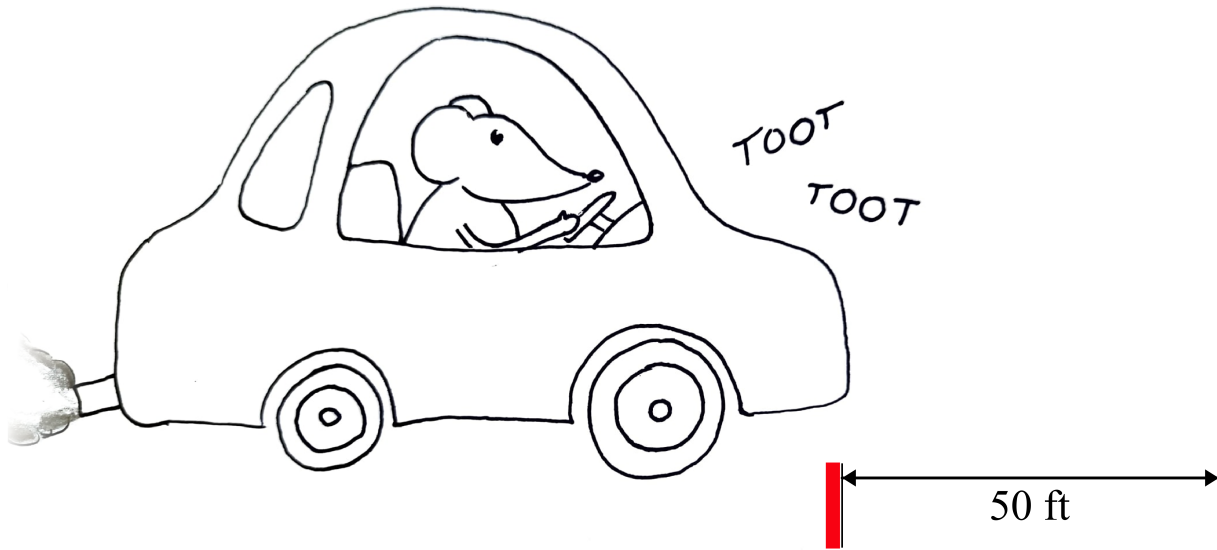


Figure 4: Rats stopped at the red marker, and we measured the stopping distance.

The `fig.scap` chunk option is for a short figure caption. Often, the figure caption in your thesis is quite long, but it is useful to have a shorter caption for the list of figures. The text in `fig.scap` will appear in your list of figures. Word currently doesn't have this option, so it's great that you can use it in R.

Figure References

At the end of the `fig.cap` chunk option, you also have the option of adding a figure label in the form of `\label{text}`. When you write a reference to Figure `\label{methods-schematic}`, $\text{\LaTeX}$ will print out the text “Figure 4”. If you reorder your figures, $\text{\LaTeX}$ will automatically change the figure numbers.

Analysis

I'm using one of R's built-in datasets (*PlantGrowth*) to show examples of inserting model summary tables, results, plots, and p-values in a paper. This sample dataset explores plant mass after applying one of

three treatment conditions (control, treatment 1 and treatment 2). I've hidden the code in the output document (chunk options `echo=F`) because you will probably not be displaying your code in your paper.

In-text R code

You can embed R code within normal text to create dynamic reports. For example, if you write `'r
nrow(plant_data)'`, this will be printed out as 30, as in:

We weighed 30 plants.

Extracting P-values

You can take this even further to embed p-values, t-test statistics, and other values within the body text - no more copying and pasting! This will save you lots of time in the results section, since R will regenerate these values each time you re-do your analysis (hurray!!). It also reduces the likelihood of mistakes.

It will take some time to find out how to extract p-values from different data types. In RStudio, always check what class your model is. Then, you can google things like “Extract p-value from an object of class `anova` in `r`”.

If you click on the model summary object in RStudio, it will open the model in a new window. You can click on any one of the green arrow icons on the right-hand side. The code required to select it will then appear in the console, where you can copy and paste it.

If you're stuck, you could also use the `str()` function to see the structure of the model. This can provide a list of the parts of the model and give you an idea of which variables you need to select the specific p-value that you want.

```
str(plant_aov_summary)
```

List of 1

Name	Type	Value
plant_aov_summary	list [1] (S3: summary.aov, listof)	List of length 1
[[1]]	list [2 x 5] (S3: anova, data.frame)	A data.frame with 2 rows and 5 columns
Df	double [2]	2 27
Sum Sq	double [2]	3.77 10.49
Mean Sq	double [2]	1.883 0.389
F value	double [2]	4.85 NA
Pr(>F)	double [2]	0.0159 NA



Figure 5: RStudio provides a handy selection tool to help you find the code needed to extract a specific value from an object. Click on the green arrow icon to see the appropriate selection code appear in your console.

```
$ :Classes 'anova' and 'data.frame':  2 obs. of  5 variables:
..$ Df      : num [1:2] 2 27
..$ Sum Sq  : num [1:2] 3.77 10.49
..$ Mean Sq: num [1:2] 1.883 0.389
..$ F value: num [1:2] 4.85 NA
..$ Pr(>F)  : num [1:2] 0.0159 NA
- attr(*, "class")= chr [1:2] "summary.aov" "listof"
```

Look at the results. If I want to extract the p-value row, it looks like I will need to write `plant_aov_summary[[1]][["Pr(>F)"]]`. The `[[1]]` is because this is a list of one, and the values we need are in the first element of the list. Notice how this returns another list:

```
plant_aov_summary[[1]][["Pr(>F)"]]
```

```
[1] 0.01590996      NA
```

The first p-value is the p-value associated with the treatment groups. The second is NA because it is for the model residuals. To extract the first p-value, add another `[[1]]` to select the first element of this list. The final code is:

```
plant_aov_summary[[1]][["Pr(>F)"]][1]]
```

```
[1] 0.01590996
```

Rounding

To make “prettier” p-values you could round them to 3 digits using the `round()` function.

```
round(plant_aov_summary[[1]][["Pr(>F)"]][1]), 3)
```

```
[1] 0.016
```

If you need to round to a specific number of significant digits, use `signif()`. This code chunk is an example of rounding to three significant digits:

```
signif(plant_aov_summary[[1]][["Pr(>F)"]][1]), 3)
```

```
[1] 0.0159
```

Now, putting it into an in-text R code block, we can write something like this with automatically inserted p-values.

Plant mass varied significantly according to treatment type ($p = 0.016$).

Tables

There are many packages that will allow you to create publication-quality tables out of summary tables in R. This is good, because the default summary tables are not visually appealing:

```
summary(plant_data_aov)
```

Df	Sum Sq	Mean Sq	F value	Pr(>F)
----	--------	---------	---------	--------

```

group          2  3.766  1.8832  4.846 0.0159 *
Residuals     27 10.492  0.3886
---
Signif. codes:  0 '***' 0.001 '**' 0.01 '*' 0.05 '.' 0.1 ' ' 1

```

The first step is to use the `tidy()` function from the `broom` library. This reformats the summary object to a tibble (a special type of dataframe) and does some automatic cleaning. For example, it removes the significance codes and converts the column names to code-friendly names with no spaces.

```

plant_data_aov %>%
  tidy()

```

```

# A tibble: 2 x 6
  term          df sumsq meansq statistic p.value
<chr>      <dbl> <dbl>  <dbl>      <dbl>  <dbl>
1 group          2  3.77  1.88        4.85  0.0159
2 Residuals     27 10.5   0.389      NA    NA

```

The next step is to round the values and re-format the p-values. The `across()` function from `dplyr` allows us to apply the same rounding function to multiple columns simultaneously. We can also change the term names to title case using `str_to_title(term)`. Lastly, we can use the `rename()` function to give the columns more useful names for a publication.

```

plant_data_aov %>%
  tidy() %>%
  mutate(
    across(sumsq:statistic, round, 2),
    p.value = round(p.value, 3),
    term = str_to_title(term)
  ) %>%
  rename(

```

```

Term = term,
'Sum of Squares' = sumsq,
'Mean Squares' = meansq,
'F-statistic' = statistic,
'p-value' = p.value
)

```

A tibble: 2 x 6

Term	df	`Sum of Squares`	`Mean Squares`	`F-statistic`	`p-value`
<chr>	<dbl>	<dbl>	<dbl>	<dbl>	<dbl>
1 Group	2	3.77	1.88	4.85	0.016
2 Residuals	27	10.5	0.39	NA	NA

The last step is to use the `kable()` package to modify the table style and presentation. The documentation for the `kable` and `kableExtra` packages has lots of useful information on the available arguments. A particularly useful argument is `align`, which allows you to specify how the text is aligned in the columns. For example, `align = c('l', 'c', 'l')` will generate columns that are left-, centre- and left-aligned.

The new code section looks like this:

```

kable(
  booktabs = T,
  linesep = '',
  escape = F,
  caption = "Plant growth varies significantly with treatments. ANOVA summary table for"
) %>%
  column_spec(1, width = "1.5in")

```

The final table looks publication-ready!

Table 1: Plant growth varies significantly with treatments. ANOVA summary table for a model examining the effect of treatment on plant mass.

Term	df	Sum of Squares	Mean Square	F	p-value
Group	2	3.76634	1.8831700	4.85	0.02
Residuals	27	10.49209	0.3885959	NA	NA

L^AT_EX Basics

You can learn a lot about L^AT_EX as you customize your paper. This is a very valuable skill, and it will be particularly useful if you’re planning to stay in academia. Most L^AT_EX commands start with a forward slash and include arguments in curly brackets. Many of them are intuitive:

Use `\setcounter{tocdepth}{2}` to set the table of content depth to header 2.

Use `\tableofcontents` to insert a table of contents.

If you want to make any cross references, you can define them using labels. You may have seen this in the *Inserting Images* section. For example, you can write `Figure label{insulin-pathway}` to automatically include the correct figure number.

It’s not recommended to do too much formatting within your document. Ideally, all of your formatting styles should be defined in the preamble.

Adorn package

Changing the formatting

If you want to change how any part of this document looks, go to `Templates/sample-preamble.tex`. For screenshots and more information, see slides 57-67 of `How-to-Write-a-Paper-in-R-PDF.pdf`.

Bibliography

To set up a bibliography, you can store your references in a plaintext file called a bib file (the filename will end with `.bib`). You can easily set this up with Zotero so the file will auto-update when you add new references. You can then cite references using code (for example use `[@smith2020]`). To learn more about this process, please see slides 68-74 of `How-to-Write-a-Paper-in-R-PDF.pdf`.

One common question is: How do I set the location of the bibliography into a custom location? R will automatically place the reference at the end of your file, but you may want to have additional content like appendices after the bibliography.

You can manually set the location of the bibliography in your document using the following text:

```
... {\#refs}  
...
```

Other Tools

To create high-quality schematics, I would highly recommend Inkscape, which is a free and open source vector editor. You're probably familiar with using the shapes tools in PowerPoint. Inkscape is like this, but you have much more control over the alignment, and many helpful tools that allow you to do more advanced techniques.

References

De La Monte, S. M., & Wands, J. R. (2005). Review of insulin and insulin-like growth factor expression, signaling, and malfunction in the central nervous system: Relevance to Alzheimer's disease. *Journal of Alzheimer's Disease*, 7(1), 45–61. <https://doi.org/10.3233/JAD-2005-7106>